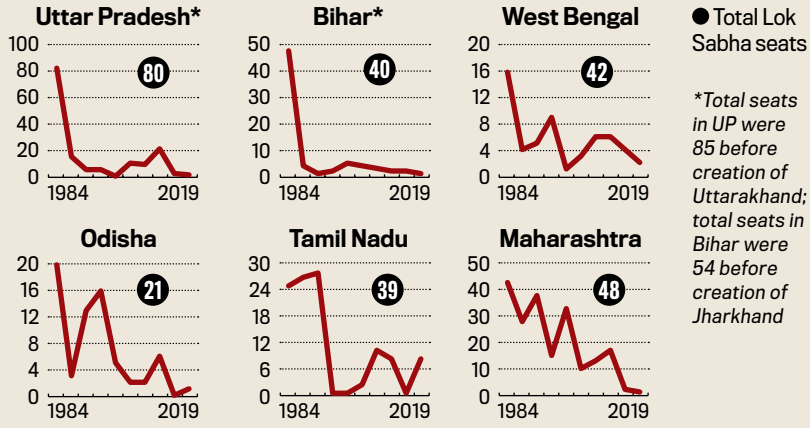
A ROADMAP TO REVIVAL

HOW TO GET BACK UP AFTER A LONG FALL

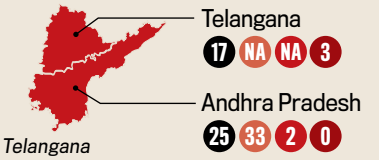
The Congress has been in decline for the past four decades in these six politically significant states that account for 270 LS seats. The party has seldom crossed double digits in these states since 1989. Any revival must start from here



**Total seats in UP were 85 before creation of Uttarakhand; total seats in Bihar were 54 before creation of Jharkhand*

LOST GROUND

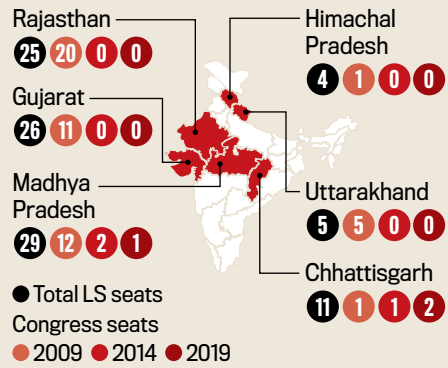
After the bifurcation of Andhra Pradesh, the Congress has almost been wiped out in the two Telugu-speaking states



**Total LS seats in AP were 42 before creation of Telangana*

AN UNEVEN DUEL

These six states, accounting for 100 LS seats, have traditionally seen a direct contest between the Congress and BJP. In the past two Lok Sabha elections, the grand old party managed just three seats, drawing zero in four states, including in Rajasthan where it was in power. With the entry of AAP, a turnaround could become even more difficult



party had been convened to pass the resolution, but the MLAs loyal to Gehlot did not turn up, openly defying the high command's diktat. Gehlot later apologised to Sonia for the embarrassment and withdrew from the presidential race.

While Gehlot saved his chair (so far), Kharge now needs to broker peace between the CM and his challenger Sachin Pilot, the former deputy CM of Rajasthan. For if a permanent solution is not brought to end the conflict, it will be a disaster in waiting for the party in the assembly election next year. More importantly, Gehlot's defiance was a direct challenge to the authority of the Gandhis. The immediate agenda in Kharge's presidency will depend on how the family responds to the affront—make peace with the reality of their dwarfed authority or show Gehlot his place.

This isn't the only duel the new Congress president will have to settle. Tensions are brewing in two other states scheduled to go to polls next year. In Chhattisgarh, CM Bhupesh Baghel is facing a challenge to his chair from health minister T.S. Singh Deo. In Karnataka, ex-chief minister Siddaramaiah and state Congress chief D.K. Shivakumar are both eyeing the big chair if the party wins the election.

Meanwhile, a bigger battle awaits Kharge outside the realm of party affairs. The rise of the BJP may have fast-tracked the electoral decimation of the Congress, but the truth is that the party has been in decline in several politically significant states such as Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, West Bengal, Odisha, Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra for nearly four decades (see *A Roadmap to Revival*). These six states account for 270 Lok Sabha seats, nearly half the strength of the Lok Sabha, and the Congress could win only 14 of them in 2019, a marginal improvement over the 10 it won in 2014. The party did little to arrest the fall in these states even though it was in power at the Centre for two of the past four decades. Two of its top leaders—Sonia and Rahul—represented UP in the Lok Sabha and the third cog of the family, Priyanka, was in charge of the state Congress unit during the 2019 Lok Sabha and 2022 assembly elections. Yet, it has been reduced to irrelevance in India's most politically significant state—with one seat in the Lok Sabha and two in the assembly.

The challenge in the north looks even more insurmountable if the party's performance is analysed in another six states, where it's in a direct contest with the BJP (see *An Uneven Duel*). These states—Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Rajasthan, MP, Gujarat and Chhattisgarh—account for 100 Lok Sabha seats. In 2018, the Congress won assembly polls in three of them—Rajasthan, MP and Chhattisgarh. Yet, in the past two general, the party won just three of the 100 seats, clearly indicating that in a battle between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Congress scion Rahul Gandhi, the latter stands little chance in these states.

Will a south Indian leader, as the new Congress chief, be able to reverse the party's fortunes in these states? Language should be no barrier as